IELTS SPEAKING

My Band 6.5 Guide

Fluency, accurate grammar and topic vocabulary, A to Z

Target	band **6.5** minimum (7 if possible)
Biggest weak point	**Fluency**: long pauses
Grammar to fix	tenses · subject–verb agreement · articles · -s/-es · he/she
Daily time	about 45 minutes

Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Exam
6–12 Nov	13–19 Nov	20–26 Nov	27 Nov →	December
Fix the base + Part 1	Part 2 + story tenses	Part 3 + longer answers	Mocks + polish	Band 6.5+

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How to use this guide: read Sections 0–8 once in the first two days. After that, use Section 11 (today's task), Section 10 (answer frameworks) and Section 9 (error log) every day. Print the Error Log pages, or copy them into your notebook. Section 14 lists every question you have asked; Section 15 is your Story Bank.

0 Know Your Target

You get four marks, and **each one is 25% of your score**:

Criterion	What the examiner checks	My focus
Fluency & Coherence (FC)	Can I keep talking without long pauses? Is my answer connected?	⭐ **Biggest weak point**
Lexical Resource (LR)	Do I have enough words for every topic, including some less common ones?	Topic vocabulary
Grammatical Range & Accuracy (GRA)	Do I mix simple and complex sentences? How many mistakes do I make?	Tense, S–V agreement, articles, -s/-es, he/she
Pronunciation (P)	Is my speech easy to understand? (Clarity matters, not a British accent.)	Keep it clear

Band 6.5 = an average like 7 + 6 + 7 + 6.

Criterion	Band 6 sounds like…	Band 7 sounds like…
FC	Speaks at length but **sometimes stops**, repeats, self-corrects a lot	Speaks at length **without noticeable effort**; uses linking words naturally
LR	Enough words to discuss topics; meaning is clear	Uses **some less common words and collocations**; can paraphrase
GRA	Mix of simple and complex sentences, but **frequent errors** in complex ones	**Many error-free sentences**; some mistakes still OK
P	Mostly clear; some words are hard to follow	Easy to understand all the time; some intonation

> **The plan:** turn **FC** and **GRA** into 7s. Grammar here does not mean fancy structures. It means **stopping the same five small mistakes** that come back again and again.

1 The Test in 3 Parts

Part	Time	What happens	What wins marks
Part 1	4–5 min	Questions about you: home, work/study, hobbies, daily life	Natural answers of **2–3 sentences**, no one-word replies
Part 2	1 min prep + **2 min talk**	A cue card ("Describe a..."). The examiner stops you at 2 min.	**Keep talking until the examiner stops you.** Use the right tense.
Part 3	4–5 min	Abstract questions linked to Part 2 (society, the future, comparisons)	Opinion + reason + example; this is where 6.5 vs 7 is decided

2 What You Need

Item	Notes
Phone voice recorder	Record **every** practice answer. Listening back is where you learn.
Voice typing	To get a transcript: **Windows: press `Win + H`**, or use the microphone on your phone keyboard, or Google Docs voice typing.
A notebook	Three sections: **Error Log** (Section 9), **Vocabulary Chunks**, **Part 2 Notes**
A timer	For Part 2 (1 min + 2 min) and for fluency drills
Cambridge IELTS 10–14	Every test has a **Speaking section** (Parts 1, 2 and 3). Use these questions for practice and mocks.

How to get feedback from me (Claude)

1. Record your answer.
2. Play it back with voice typing on, or transcribe it yourself. **Don't correct anything**, because I need to see your real mistakes.
3. Write `...` wherever you paused for more than 2 seconds.
4. Paste it here with the question and how long you spoke (e.g. "*Part 2, 1 min 35 sec*").
5. I'll mark it on the four criteria and list every T / SV / A / S / HS mistake (see Section 9).

> Voice typing sometimes "fixes" your grammar or mishears words. If a sentence looks too perfect, listen again and write what you really said.

3 Focus 1: Fluency (My Biggest Weak Point)

Fluency is **not** speaking fast. It is **not stopping**. Examiners punish long silences much more than small mistakes.

3.1 The golden rule

> **Don't stop to fix small mistakes.** If you notice a mistake, correct it once quickly ("...he go, sorry, he goes...") and keep going. If you're not sure, just carry on.

Train accuracy in **drills** (Sections 4–6). In the exam, **keep talking**.

3.2 Answer extenders: never give one-line answers

Part 1: A + R + E (Answer + Reason + Example/Extra)

> **Q:** Do you like cooking? ❌ *"Yes, I like."* (too short, and wrong grammar) ✅ *"Yes, I **do**, actually. I find it quite relaxing after a long day. For example, on Fridays I usually cook biryani for my family, and they **love** it."*

Part 3: O + R + E + C (Opinion + Reason + Example + Contrast)

> **Q:** Do you think children spend too much time on phones? ✅ *"**I'd say** yes, in most cases. **The main reason is that** phones are designed to be addictive, so kids find it hard to stop. **For instance,** my nephew **spends** almost four hours a day on YouTube. **Having said that,** phones **can** be useful for learning if parents **set** some limits."*

3.3 Thinking-time phrases (use these instead of silence)

Situation	Say this
Need a second to think	*"Well, let me think..."* / *"That's an interesting question..."*
Never thought about it	*"I've never really thought about that, but I guess..."*
Hard question	*"That's a tricky one. I suppose it depends on..."*
Forgot a word	*"...the thing you use to... what's it called... the remote control."* (Explaining around a word is a **skill**, not a failure.)
Didn't understand	*"Sorry, could you repeat the question, please?"* (OK once or twice)

> Don't use the same filler every time. "Actually" and "basically" in every sentence sound robotic.

3.4 Linking words (these connect your ideas, which is the "Coherence" half of FC)

Job	Words
Add	*also, on top of that, what's more, another thing is*

Job	Words
Reason	*because, since, the main reason is that, that's why*
Example	*for example, for instance, like, such as*
Contrast	*but, although, however, having said that, on the other hand*
Result	*so, as a result, that's why*
Time (Part 2)	*at first, after that, then, eventually, in the end*
Opinion	*I'd say, personally, in my view, I think, it seems to me*

Linkers in a Part 2 answer (asked 7 Nov). Too few linkers sound robotic, but **too many sound memorised**. If almost every sentence starts with *Moreover / On top of that / More importantly*, the examiner thinks you are reciting. Natural speakers mostly join ideas *inside* the sentence with **and, but, so, because, also**.

The simple rule: use a linker only when it does a real job.

Job	Natural spoken linker
Start the talk	**Well,** I would like to talk about...
Move to a new prompt (only 1–2 per answer)	**As for his achievements,** ...
Add one more point (once)	**Besides,** ... or just use **also** inside the sentence: *He is also...*
Contrast	**but** / **Although** ...
Example	**For example,** ...
Personal comment	**Actually,** ... / **To be honest,** ...
Link to the "why"	**That is why** I'm a big fan of his.

Test: remove the linker. If the meaning is still clear and the sentence still flows, you don't need it.

Avoid in Speaking: *Moreover, Furthermore, In addition, More importantly, Overall*. These are essay words, and too many of them sound memorised.

About 6–8 linkers in a 2-minute answer is enough, plus your normal *and / but / so / also*.

> Model answers: cards 105 and 117 in the Person Topics book, with the linkers in **bold**.

3.5 Daily fluency drills (pick 2 per day)

Drill	How	Time
1-minute non-stop	Pick any topic (my phone, rain, breakfast). Talk for 60 seconds **without stopping**. Count your pauses. Goal: 0 pauses over 2 seconds.	5 min
4-3-2	Tell the same Part 2 story in **4 minutes**, then **3**, then **2**. Each round gets smoother and faster.	10 min
Shadowing	Play 1–2 minutes of Listening audio you've already done (Cambridge Part 1 or 3). Repeat **just behind** the speaker, copying rhythm and stress. (This also helps your Listening.)	10 min
Narrate your day	While walking or cooking, describe what you're doing in English, in your head or out loud. "Now I'm cutting onions, which always **makes** me cry..."	any time
Re-record	Record an answer, listen, note the mistakes, record it **again**. The second version is always better, and that's how you improve.	10 min

3.6 Measuring my fluency (speed + pauses)

> There's **no official speed** in the band descriptors, and examiners don't count words. They listen for **effort, hesitation and connection**. These numbers are rough benchmarks for **checking myself**.

Speed benchmarks

Speed (words/min)	How it usually sounds
under 80	Slow and hesitant, which usually keeps fluency at band 5
80–100	A bit slow; OK if there are very few long pauses
100–140	✅ **Target zone for band 6.5–7**
130–160	Normal native-speaker conversation
170+	Too fast for me now: more mistakes and unclear words, which hurts Pronunciation

Minimum: about 100 words/min (200+ words in Part 2). Comfortable target: **110–130 words/min (220–260 words in 2 minutes)**.

What matters more than speed

Measure	How to count	Band 6.5 target
Long pauses (2–3+ sec)	Mark `...` in the transcript	**0–2 per minute**
Where I pause	Between ideas is fine. In the middle of a phrase is bad: "*I went to... the... market*"	Only between sentences or ideas
Run length (words between pauses)	Average across the answer	**6+ words**
Restarts ("*I go, I went...*")	Count them	**2 or fewer per minute**
Part 2 length	Timer	**The full 2:00**

> **Priority:** reduce **pauses** first, and speed will come naturally. 100 words/min with no long pauses sounds more fluent than 140 with a stop every 5 seconds.

Weekly check (5 minutes): record a 1-minute answer → **Win + H** voice typing → count words (paste into Word, or send it to Claude) → count `...` pauses and restarts → fill in the tracker.

Date	Topic	Words/min	Long pauses	Restarts	Notes

4 Focus 2: Correct Tenses

4.1 The question tells you the tense

This is the most useful trick: **listen to the verb in the question and answer in the same tense.**

The question says...	Use	Example answer
Do you...? / What do you usually...?	**Present simple**	*I **usually go** to the gym in the evening.*
Are you...ing at the moment?	**Present continuous**	*I'**m preparing** for IELTS right now.*
Did you...? / When you were a child...?	**Past simple**	*I **played** cricket every afternoon.*
Have you ever...?	**Present perfect**, then **past simple** for details	*Yes, I'**ve been** to Cox's Bazar. I **went** there last winter.*
How long have you...?	**Present perfect (continuous)**	*I'**ve lived** here **for** ten years / **since** 2016.*
Will you...? / In the future...?	**will / going to**	*I think I'**ll** live abroad. I'**m going to** apply next year.*
How has ... changed?	**Present perfect + used to**	*Dhaka **has become** much busier. People **used to** walk more.*
Would you like to...?	**would**	*Yes, I'**d love** to. It **would** be amazing.*
Part 2: "Describe a time when... / a trip you took"	**Past simple** for the whole story	*It **was** two years ago. We **took** a bus...*
Part 2: "Describe a person you admire"	**Present simple** (they're still alive and still like that)	*She **is** my aunt. She **works** as a doctor.*

4.2 My common tense mistakes (Bangla → English)

❌ Wrong	✅ Right	Why
*Yesterday I **go** to market.*	*Yesterday I **went** to **the** market.*	Past time → past simple
*I **am going** there every day.*	*I **go** there every day.*	Habits use present simple, not -ing
*I **have gone** there last year.*	*I **went** there last year.*	A finished time (last year, in 2020) → past simple
*I **am living** here **since** 5 years.*	*I'**ve lived** here **for** 5 years.*	Duration up to now → present perfect + *for*
*I **am knowing** him.*	*I **know** him.*	*know, like, want, need, have (own)* don't take -ing
*When I was child, I **like** mangoes.*	*When I was **a** child, I **liked** mangoes.*	The whole sentence stays in the past

4.3 Part 2 tense check

In the **1-minute prep**, write **PAST** or **PRESENT** at the top of your notes. Look at it while you speak.

Mixed cards (asked 8 Nov): some cards have a past event *and* a person who still exists, for example *"a person you met once"*. Use both tenses:

What you describe	Tense	Example
The **event** (the meeting, what happened)	**Past simple**	*I **met** him last month. That meeting **was** like a breath of fresh air.*
The **person** (what they are like now)	**Present simple**	*He **is** very sociable. He **studies** music.*
Your experience **up to now** (no time given)	**Present perfect**	*I **have met** him only once.*
Your **feeling now**	**Present simple**	*I **feel** inspired by him.*

> **Check the meaning too:** *"he **is** like a breath of fresh air in my hectic lifestyle"* is correct grammar, but it means he is part of your daily life. For someone you met once, *"that meeting **was** like a breath of fresh air"* is more logical.

4.4 Talking about past habits (used to / would + more)

used to + V1 vs would + V1

	used to + V1	would + V1
Repeated **actions**	✅ *I **used to** play cricket every afternoon.*	✅ *I **would** play cricket every afternoon.*
States (be, have, live, like, know, love)	✅ *I **used to** live in Comilla. / I **used to** be very shy.*	❌ *I would live in Comilla. /* ❌ *I would be very shy.*

> **Rule: used to** works for everything. **would** only works for **repeated actions**, never states. **Order:** start with **used to** to set the past scene, then switch to **would** for the details. If you start with *would*, it can sound like "imagine" instead of "past habit".

Common mistakes

❌ Wrong	✅ Right	Why
*I **use to** play…*	*I **used to** play…*	Always **-d** in positive sentences (it sounds like "yoos-tuh")
*I didn't **used to** like vegetables.*	*I didn't **use to** like vegetables.*	After *did / didn't*, drop the -d
*I **was used to** play football.*	*I **used to** play football.*	*was used to* means something different (see below)
I would be very naughty.	*I **used to** be very naughty.*	*be* is a state, so *would* isn't possible
*He **would** suffer from a hormone problem as a child.*	*He **suffered** from a growth hormone deficiency as a child.*	An illness or condition is a **state**, not a repeated action, so use past simple (or *used to suffer*), never *would*
*He **used to win** several music competitions.*	*He **won** several music competitions.*	When you give a **number** (*several, three, many times*), use past simple. *Used to* is for a habit with no count (8 Nov)

> **Don't confuse:** *I **used to** wake up early* (I did it in the past, but not now) ≠ *I**'m used to** waking up early* (I'm accustomed to it, so it isn't difficult).

More ways to describe past habits (don't use *used to* 10 times in one answer, but mix these)

Structure	Example
Past simple + frequency word	*We **often / usually / always** played cricket after school.*
every / most + time	***Every Friday**, we went to the river. / **Most weekends**, we…*
spent + time + -ing	*We **spent hours chatting** about cricket.*
whenever	***Whenever** it rained, we **would** sit under the tree.*
Hardly a day went by without…	***Hardly a day went by without** us meeting.* ⭐ band 7
It was a habit of ours to…	*It was **a habit of ours to** have tea together.*
got into the habit of + -ing	*We **got into the habit of** studying together.*
tended to + V1	*We **tended to** stay out until it got dark.*
always + past continuous (fun or annoying habits)	*We **were always getting** into trouble!*

Is past simple + *usually* correct for a past habit? ✅ **Yes.** It's normal and natural.

> ❌ *I usually went to our **grandparent's** house **on** summer vacation.* ✅ *I usually went to **my grandparents'** house **during the summer holidays**.*

Point	Rule
grandparents'	Plural noun ending in -s → apostrophe **after** the s: *my grandparents' house, my parents' room*. (*grandparent's* = only one grandparent)
during the summer holidays	Natural British English. *on summer vacation* is American, also OK: *on my summer vacation*.
Where *usually / often / always* goes	**Before** the main verb: *I **usually went**…* · **After** *was/were*: *I **was usually** very excited.*

> **"My instructor said *usually* is only for the present tense."** That's a **simplified exam strategy**, not a grammar rule. *Usually* + past simple is correct, standard English and is **not** marked as a mistake. The strategy is still good: *used to / would* make the habit **clear straight away** (past simple alone can sound like a single event), and they show the examiner **grammatical range**.

My approach:

Use	How much
used to and **would**	Main forms for past habits (instructor's method)
past simple + usually / often	Once or twice, for variety
would usually	✅ natural: *We **would usually** leave early in the morning.*
❌ **used to usually**	Avoid: *I used to usually go…* sounds awkward, so pick one

⭐ Simple rule card: past habits for band 6.5

Form	Example	Use for
used to + V1	*I **used to** live in a village.*	**Start** the story · actions **and** states
would + V1	*We **would** swim in the pond.*	Repeated **actions** only
would + usually + V1	*We **would usually** leave early.*	Actions, "most of the time"
would + often + V1	*My grandmother **would often** cook pitha for us.*	Actions, "many times"
(extra) past simple + usually/often	*I **usually went** there in summer.*	Variety, once or twice (optional)

> **The one rule: *would* never goes with states** (*be, have, live, like, know, love*), so use *used to* for those. ❌ *I would be very shy.* → ✅ *I **used to** be very shy.*
>
> *"When I was a child, I **used to** spend every summer in my grandparents' village. I **used to** love it there. My cousins and I **would** swim in the pond for hours, and we **would usually** come home only when we got hungry. My grandmother **would often** make pitha for us in the evening."*

Recommended mix for one answer: *used to* (once, at the start) → *would* (2–3 times) → past simple + *usually/often* → *spent hours -ing* → *whenever* → one band 7 phrase.

Keep talking for 2 minutes: the 6 layers (when you run out of ideas, move to the next layer)

Layer	What to add	Tense
1. **Who + when**	the friend's name, your age, where you lived	*used to*
2. **The routine**	what you did, how often, how long	*would*, past simple + *usually*
3. **The place / details**	describe the place, people, food, sounds	past simple, *there was/were*, *who/which* clauses
4. **One specific memory** ⭐	one day that stands out	past continuous + past simple: *One day, **while** we **were** sitting there, he suddenly **told** me…*
5. **Feelings**	why it mattered	*Looking back, … / so … that …*
6. **Past vs now**	do you still do it?	present simple + *not as often as we used to*

> Layer 4 makes the biggest difference. A single story always fills 30 seconds easily.

Model: Part 2, *Describe something you often did with a friend* (notes: **PAST** · **HE**)

> *"I'd like to talk about something I **used to** do with my best friend, Tanvir, when we were in secondary school. Almost every afternoon after school, we **would** ride our bicycles to a small tea stall near the river. We **usually** ordered two cups of milk tea and some singara, and we **spent hours chatting** about cricket, exams and our future plans.*
>
> *The place itself was quite simple. **There was** a wooden bench under a huge banyan tree, and the owner, an old man **who** knew us very well, **would always** save that bench for us. **Whenever** it rained, we **would** sit there and watch the river. Honestly, **hardly a day went by without** us going there, even during exam time.*
>
> *I remember one particular day **when we were sitting** there and Tanvir suddenly **told** me that his family **was moving** to Chittagong. I was **so** shocked **that** I couldn't say anything for a few minutes.*
>
> ***Looking back**, those afternoons were probably the happiest part of my teenage years. These days, Tanvir and I don't meet **as often as we used to**, because we're both busy, but **whenever** we do meet, we still go to that tea stall. It **has become** a kind of tradition for us."*

Notice: the friend is **he** every time (*Tanvir… his family*), and the tense moves from **past habit** to **one past story** to **now**. That change in time is what gives you variety.

Part 1 version (2–3 sentences)

> **Q:** What did you often do with your friends as a child? *"We **used to** play cricket in the field behind my house. Every evening, we **would** play until it got dark, and our mothers **would** have to call us home for dinner!"*

5 Focus 3: Subject–Verb Agreement and -s/-es

5.1 The one rule

> **He / She / It / one person / one thing → verb + s.** *I play, you play, we play, they play* → but *he play**s**, she play**s**, my brother play**s***.

5.2 Spelling the -s

Verb ends in…	Add	Examples
most verbs	**-s**	works, likes, plays, reads
-s, -sh, -ch, -x, -o	**-es**	watches, washes, misses, fixes, goes, does
consonant + y	**-ies**	studies, tries, carries, cries
vowel + y	**-s**	plays, enjoys, buys
have	→ **has**	she **has** two cats

5.3 Traps

❌ Wrong	✅ Right	Trap
*My mother **cook** very well.*	*My mother **cooks** very well.*	"My mother" = she
*He **don't** like tea.*	*He **doesn't** like tea.*	do → **does** for he/she/it
*Does she **likes** it?*	*Does she **like** it?*	After *does/doesn't*, no -s
*People **is** very friendly.*	*People **are** very friendly.*	**People** is plural
*Everyone **have** a phone.*	*Everyone **has** a phone.*	*Everyone, everybody, nobody* are singular
*One of my friends **are** a doctor.*	*One of my friends **is** a doctor.*	The subject is **one**
*There **is** many parks.*	*There **are** many parks.*	There **is** + one / There **are** + many
*My family **are/is**…*	*My family **is** quite big.*	Both are OK; **is** is safest
*The news **are** bad.*	*The news **is** bad.*	*News* is singular

5.4 Plural -s on nouns

Bangla often marks plurals with words (অনেক বন্ধু) instead of an ending. English needs **both**:

> *many friend**s**, two brother**s**, a lot of student**s**, one of my **cousins*** ❌ *many friend, few people**s*** (people is already plural)

6 Focus 4: Articles (a / an / the) and He/She

6.1 Articles: the 5 rules that cover 90%

Bangla has no articles, so you have to **add** them on purpose.

Rule	Example
a/an + one countable thing, first mention, or a job	*I have **a** bike. My sister is **an** engineer.*
the = we both know which one	*I went to **the** park near my house. **The** park was crowded.*
the + only one / superlatives	***the** sun, **the** internet, **the** best, **the** most popular*
No article + general plural/uncountable things	*I like ∅ dogs. ∅ Money isn't everything. ∅ Education is important.*
No article + meals, most countries, cities, languages, sports	*have ∅ breakfast, in ∅ Bangladesh, speak ∅ Bangla, play ∅ football*

6.2 Fixed phrases (learn them as chunks)

With **the**	With **no** article
in **the** morning / afternoon / evening	at night, at home, at work
go to **the** cinema / market / gym	go to school / university / bed / work
play **the** guitar / piano	play cricket / football
on **the** internet, on **the** phone	by bus, by car, on foot
the same, **the** USA, **the** UK	watch TV, listen to music
at **the** weekend	last year, next week

> **Quick test:** before any singular countable noun (*phone, friend, house, job*), you **must** have something in front: *a / the / my / this / one*. ❌ *I bought phone.* ✅ *I bought **a** phone.*

6.3 He/She mix-ups

Bangla uses **সে** for both men and women, so your brain doesn't separate them automatically.

Fix	How
Part 2 notes	Write a big **HE** or **SHE** at the top of the card when it's about a person.
Match the whole set	**she – her – hers – herself** / **he – him – his – himself**
Drill	Describe your mother for 1 minute, then your father for 1 minute. Record it and count every wrong pronoun.
Use the name	If you feel unsure, repeat the name once: "*...and Rina, she's my cousin...*". It resets your brain.

Common mix-ups: ❌ *My mother... **he** is a teacher.* ❌ *My father loves **her** job.* ✅ *My father loves **his** job.*

7 Focus 5: Topic Vocabulary

7.1 How to learn vocabulary for Speaking

- **Learn chunks, not single words.** *Heavy traffic*, not "traffic". *A hectic schedule*, not "hectic".
- **Make it about YOU.** For every chunk, say one sentence about your own life. "*I have a hectic schedule these days because of IELTS.*"
- **5–8 chunks a day** is enough. More than that, and you'll forget them.
- **Review** the chunks on Day 1, Day 3 and Day 7.
- **Say it, don't just read it.** A word you've only read won't come out under pressure.

7.2 What makes vocabulary "band 7"

Feature	Band 6	Band 7
Precise words	*very good, very bad*	*beneficial, harmful, convenient, stressful*
Collocations	*do a mistake, big rain*	*make a mistake, heavy rain*
Idioms (a few, used correctly)	none	*once in a blue moon, not my cup of tea*
Paraphrase	repeats the examiner's words	**Q:** *Do you like reading?* → "*Yes, I'm a big fan of* ***books****...*"

⚠️ Don't push idioms into every answer. One or two natural idioms in the whole test are enough. Forced idioms sound memorised.

7.3 Topic list (vocabulary banks to build next)

#	Topic group	Covers
1	**Hometown & accommodation**	city/village life, home, neighbourhood, traffic
2	**Work & study**	job, university, subjects, teachers, exams
3	**Family & friends**	relationships, personality, people you admire
4	**Free time & hobbies**	reading, music, films, sports, games
5	**Technology & internet**	phones, social media, apps, online learning
6	**Food & health**	cooking, restaurants, diet, exercise, sleep
7	**Travel & transport**	trips, holidays, public transport, tourism
8	**Shopping & money**	shopping habits, online shopping, saving
9	**Environment & weather**	seasons, pollution, nature, climate
10	**Culture & festivals**	Eid, Pohela Boishakh, weddings, traditions
11	**Media & news**	TV, newspapers, advertising, celebrities
12	**Objects, places & events**	Part 2: gifts, buildings, parks, celebrations, achievements

7.4 Sample: Topic 1, Hometown (the full bank comes later)

Chunk	My sentence
a bustling city	*Dhaka is a bustling city that never really sleeps.*
heavy traffic / traffic jams	*The heavy traffic is the worst thing about living here.*
densely populated	*My area is very densely populated.*
a peaceful neighbourhood	*I'd love to move to a more peaceful neighbourhood.*
within walking distance	*My university is within walking distance of my flat.*
have a lot going on	*There's always a lot going on in the city centre.*
grow up in	*I grew up in a small town near Comilla.*

7.5 My Word Bank: Person (words I chose)

> **Goal:** use **3–4 of these words** in every person topic (Part 2 "Describe a person..." and the Part 3 questions after it). Don't try to fit all of them into one answer, because that sounds memorised. New words get added here as I share them.

Character

Word (say it)	Bangla	Use it like this	Opposite (for Part 3 contrast)
promising (PROM-i-sing)	সম্ভাবনাময়	*a promising student / young player → My cousin is a **promising** cricketer; he's only 16, but he already plays for the district team.*	—
reliable (ri-LIE-a-ble)	নির্ভরযোগ্য	*someone I can rely on → She's very **reliable**. If she says she'll do something, she always does it.*	unreliable
diligent (DIL-i-jent)	পরিশ্রমী, মনোযোগী	*a diligent worker / student → My father is extremely **diligent**; he has never missed a day of work.*	lazy
considerate (con-SID-er-ate)	অন্যের কথা ভাবে, বিবেচক	*considerate of others → He's very **considerate**. He always asks how I'm doing before talking about himself.*	inconsiderate, selfish
sociable (SOH-sha-ble)	মিশুক	*very sociable, gets on well with everyone → She's so **sociable** that she makes friends wherever she goes.*	shy, reserved
frank (FRANK)	খোলামেলা, স্পষ্টভাষী	*frank and honest → I like him because he's **frank**; he tells me the truth even when it hurts.*	—
intelligent (in-TEL-i-jent)	বুদ্ধিমান	*highly intelligent → My teacher was **highly intelligent**, but she explained things in a very simple way.*	—
polite (po-LITE)	ভদ্র, নম্র	*polite **to** everyone → He's always **polite to** everyone, even to strangers.*	rude
punctual (PUNK-chu-al)	সময়ানুবর্তী	*always punctual, never late → She's very **punctual**; she arrives ten minutes early for every meeting.*	always late
sensible (SEN-si-ble)	বিচক্ষণ, বাস্তববাদী	*a sensible decision / person → My elder brother is very **sensible**, so I ask him for advice before big decisions.*	foolish, careless

Appearance and style

Word (say it)	Bangla	Use it like this	Opposite
elegant (EL-e-gant)	রুচিশীল, মার্জিত	*dresses elegantly / an elegant woman → My aunt always **dresses elegantly**, usually in a simple cotton saree.*	—
stunning (STUN-ning)	অসাধারণ সুন্দর	*she looks stunning / a stunning view → She **looked stunning** at her wedding.*	—

Way of talking

Word (say it)	Bangla	Use it like this	Opposite
a smooth talker (smooth TALK-er)	কথায় ভোলাতে পারে এমন	*he's a bit of a smooth talker → My uncle is **a bit of a smooth talker**. He can convince anyone to buy anything!*	—

⚠️ **Careful with these:**

- **promising** = *likely to be successful in the future*. It does **not** mean "someone who keeps promises". (For that, say *reliable* or *a man of his word*.)
- **a smooth talker** is usually **not a compliment**. It suggests someone who is charming but maybe not completely honest. Use it with a smile, as in the uncle example. For real praise, say *a great speaker* or *very persuasive*.
- **sensible** (বিচক্ষণ) ≠ **sensitive** (সংবেদনশীল / easily hurt).
- **stunning** is for looks and places, and is used more often for women. For a man, say *very handsome* or *always well dressed*.
- Say **polite *to*** someone, not *polite with*.

Which words fit which cue card

Part 2 topic	Best words
A person you admire	diligent, reliable, considerate, intelligent, sensible
A friend / a good friend	sociable, frank, reliable, considerate
A teacher who helped you	intelligent, diligent, punctual, sensible
A young person / a talented person	promising, diligent, intelligent
A family member (parent, sibling, relative)	considerate, sensible, reliable, polite
A famous person / someone well dressed	stunning, elegant, intelligent
A person who is good at persuading / talks a lot	a smooth talker, sociable, frank
A colleague, classmate or neighbour	punctual, reliable, polite, sociable

Model: the words in action (Part 2, *Describe a person you admire*, notes: **PRESENT** · **SHE**)

> *"I'd like to talk about my aunt, Rina, who **works** as a doctor in Dhaka. The first thing I admire about her is that she's incredibly **diligent**. She **works** long hours at the hospital, but she never **complains**. She's also very **considerate**. Even when she's exhausted, she always **asks** about my studies and **gives** me useful advice. On top of that, she's extremely **punctual**; I've never seen her arrive late for anything. And she **dresses** quite **elegantly**, usually in a simple cotton saree. I remember one time when I was worried about my university admission. She sat with me for two hours and helped me make a **sensible** plan. That's why she **means** so much to me. She's not just my aunt, she's my role model."*

Notice: **she** every time, and **-s** on every present-tense verb after *she* (*works, complains, asks, gives, dresses, means*).

8 Pronunciation (Quick Fixes)

You don't need a foreign accent. You need to be **clear**. These sounds are the usual problems for Bangla speakers:

Sound	Practise	Common mistake
v (teeth on lip) vs **w** (round lips)	*very, village, video / west, water, wonderful*	"bhery", "wery"
z	*zero, zoo, easy, busy*	"jero", "eaji"
s vs **sh**	*sea / she, save / shave*	mixing them up
s + consonant at the start	*school, station, sport, speak*	"ishkul", "isteshon"
th	*think, three / this, mother*	"tink", "dis" (OK if clear, but try)
Word endings	*work**ed**, play**s**, friend**s***	dropping the ending also sounds like a grammar mistake
Word stress	*PHO-to-graph, pho-TO-gra-phy, e-co-NO-mic*	flat stress on every syllable

Intonation: let your voice go up and down. A flat, monotone voice sounds memorised and keeps P at 6. Shadowing (Section 3.5) fixes this better than anything else.

9 Error Log (Use After Every Recording)

Write every mistake and give it a code:

Code	Mistake	Example
T	Wrong tense	*Yesterday I go*
SV	Subject–verb agreement (missing -s, *don't/doesn't, is/are*)	*She like, people is*
A	Missing or wrong article	*I bought phone*
PL	Missing plural -s on a noun	*many friend*
HS	He/she, his/her mix-up	*my mother… he*
WF	Wrong word form or collocation	*I am very interesting in music, do a mistake*
P	Pause longer than 2 seconds	`. . .`
SH	Answer too short (Part 1 under 2 sentences, Part 2 under 1:45)	—

Error Log

Date	Part / Question	My sentence	Correct sentence	Code
6 Nov	P1 – cooking	My mother cook well	My mother **cooks** well	SV

Weekly Code Count

Week	T	SV	A	PL	HS	WF	P	SH	Next week's drill
Week 1									
Week 2									
Week 3									
Week 4									

At the end of each week, **count the codes. The biggest code is next week's main drill.**

10 Answer Frameworks

Part 1: A + R + E (15–25 seconds per answer)

> **Q:** Do you prefer mornings or evenings? "***I'd say*** *evenings,* ***definitely****.* ***The thing is,*** *I'm not really a morning person, so I feel more energetic later in the day.* ***For example,*** *I* ***do*** *most of my IELTS practice after 8 pm.*"

Part 2: The 1-minute notes plan

Don't write sentences. Write **keywords** in 5 boxes:

```
[ PAST / PRESENT ]          [ HE / SHE ]
1. What / who:  ...
2. When / where: ...
3. Details (cue-card points): ...
4. Story / example: ...
5. Feeling / why it matters: ...
```

Talk structure (fill the 2 minutes):

1. **Intro (10 sec):** "*I'd like to talk about...*"
2. **Cue-card points (60 sec):** answer each bullet point, adding a detail to each.
3. **A small story or example (30 sec):** "*I remember one time when...*"
4. **Feelings / why it's important (20 sec):** "*The reason this means so much to me is...*"
5. **If you still have time:** add more detail. **Never stop early.** Let the examiner stop you.

How much content is enough for Part 2?

Rule	Why
2 minutes ≈ 220–260 words (see 3.6)	About **4 ideas** fully developed. 10 ideas in one sentence each runs over time *and* sounds like a list.
Depth beats breadth	Develop each idea with details, feelings and one short story (the 6 layers in 4.4). This is what band 7 sounds like.
Read the card carefully	"*Describe* ***a*** *childhood memory*" = **one** story in depth. "*your childhood*" = 3–4 memories is fine.
Save the extra ideas	Put them in **Section 15 (My Story Bank)**, because each one becomes another cue card answer.

Part 3: O + R + E + C (30–45 seconds per answer)

Question type	Opening phrase
Opinion	*I'd say... / Personally, I think...*
Compare (past vs now)	*Compared to the past, ... has changed a lot. People used to... but now...*
Future	*I imagine that in the future... / It's likely that...*

Question type	Opening phrase
Advantages / disadvantages	*The biggest benefit is… but on the downside…*
Why?	*There are a couple of reasons. Firstly… Another reason is…*
Not sure	*It's hard to say, but I suppose it depends on…*

Range of grammar to use naturally in Part 3:

- *If* clauses: *If the government **invested** more in transport, traffic **would** improve.*
- Relative clauses: *People **who** live in cities…*
- Passive: *A lot of trees **have been cut down**.*
- Comparatives: *…much **more expensive than** it **used to** be.*

11 The 4-Week Plan (6 Nov → early December)

Daily routine (about 45 minutes)

Block	Time	What
Vocabulary	10 min	5–8 new chunks from this week's topics + review old chunks
Grammar drill	10 min	Your biggest error code (Sections 4–6)
Fluency drill	10 min	Two drills from Section 3.5
Record + check	15 min	Answer exam questions → record → error log → re-record

Week 1 (6–12 Nov): Fix the base + Part 1

Focus	Tasks
Grammar	Sections 4, 5 and 6: learn the tables and say the ✅ sentences out loud
Vocabulary	Topics 1–4 (hometown, work/study, family, hobbies)
Speaking	Part 1 only: 10 questions a day, A + R + E, recorded
Fluency	1-minute non-stop every day
End of week	Send me 5 Part 1 answers (transcript) for marking

Week 2 (13–19 Nov): Part 2 + tenses in stories

Focus	Tasks
Grammar	Past simple stories; HE/SHE drill (describe 5 different people)
Vocabulary	Topics 5–8
Speaking	**One Part 2 card a day**: 1 min prep, full 2 min, recorded, then 4-3-2 on the same card
End of week	Send me 2 Part 2 transcripts with timings

Week 3 (20–26 Nov): Part 3 + longer answers

Focus	Tasks
Grammar	Range: *if* clauses, *used to*, present perfect, comparatives
Vocabulary	Topics 9–12
Speaking	Part 2 + its Part 3 questions every day (O + R + E + C)
End of week	**Mock test 1:** full Parts 1–3 from Cambridge 13 Test 1; send me the transcript

Week 4 (27 Nov → exam): Mocks + polish

Focus	Tasks
Mocks	Every 2 days, a full speaking test (Cambridge 13–14), recorded, timed, with no stopping or restarting

Focus	Tasks
Fix	Error log → drill only the top 2 codes
Vocabulary	Review all chunks; no new topics
Last 2 days	Light practice only: speak English all day, sleep well

> **Keep Cambridge 13–14 Speaking tests for mocks**, the same as in your Listening plan.

12 Exam Day Checklist

Before you go in

☐ Speak English for 15–20 minutes before the test (warm up your mouth and brain)

☐ Remember: **the examiner is not your enemy.** It's a conversation, not an interrogation.

During the test

☐ Part 1: **2–3 sentences** every time (A + R + E)

☐ Listen to the **tense of the question** and answer in the same tense

☐ Part 2: write **PAST/PRESENT** and **HE/SHE** on your notes

☐ Part 2: **don't stop** before the examiner says so

☐ Part 3: **opinion + reason + example + contrast**

☐ Forgot a word? **Explain around it.** Don't stop.

☐ Made a small mistake? Fix it once quickly or ignore it, and **keep going**

☐ He → **his**, she → **her**; my mother → **she**; people → **are**; everyone → **has**

Never

☐ ❌ Give memorised answers (examiners are trained to spot them and lower your score)

☐ ❌ Go silent for more than a few seconds

☐ ❌ Answer with just "Yes" or "No"

13 Resources to Build Next

#	Resource	Status
1	Topic Vocabulary Bank: 12 topics, chunks + model sentences	🟡 started: **Person** bank in Section 7.5
2	Grammar Fix Drills: tense, S–V, articles, -s/-es, he/she (fill-the-gap + speak-aloud)	⏳
3	Part 1 question bank with model A + R + E answers	⏳
4	Part 2 cue cards with notes + model answers	🟡 started: **Person Topics** book (`IELTS_Speaking_Person_Topics`), 33 Makkar person cards + vocabulary + reusable sentences; answers built from my ideas
5	Part 3 question bank with O + R + E + C models	⏳
6	Fluency drill pack (1-minute topics, 4-3-2 cards)	⏳

14 My Questions (Index)

Every doubt I ask gets answered **inside this guide**. This table shows where to find each answer.

Date	My question	Answer in
5 Nov	Can I use *used to + V1* and *would + V1* for past regular activity?	**4.4**: used to vs would, common mistakes, *be used to + -ing*
5 Nov	How do I keep talking longer and with more variety in a cue card about past habits? Are there other ways to describe past habits?	**4.4**: more ways, the 6 layers, model answer
5 Nov	Which person words should I use in person topics?	**7.5**: My Word Bank: Person
5 Nov	Is "*I usually went to our grandparent's house on summer vacation*" correct?	**4.4**: past simple + *usually*, *grandparents'*, adverb position
5 Nov	My instructor said *usually* is only for the present tense, and to use only *used to / would*. Is that right?	**4.4**: "My instructor said..." box + My approach
5 Nov	So my simple set is *used to*, *would*, *would usually*, *would often* + V1?	**4.4**: ⭐ Simple rule card: past habits
5 Nov	Are my Bangla ideas for "childhood memories" enough for a cue card, or too short?	**10**: How much content is enough · **15**: Story Bank + model answer
5 Nov	My approach: simple sentences and idea lists first, cue card versions later	**15.3**: My 2-stage method · **15.4**: Stage 1 childhood sentences
5 Nov	How do I measure fluency? How many words per minute should I speak, and what's the minimum speed?	**3.6**: Measuring my fluency + weekly tracker
6 Nov	Check my class handout (person topics + best friend sample answer)	**15.6**: corrected best friend model + main fixes (class words are in the Person Topics vocabulary)
7 Nov	"*he would / used to suffer hormone deficiency*": would or used to?	**4.4**: Common mistakes (an illness is a state, so use past simple)
7 Nov	My cue card sounds robotic without linkers. Where do I put them?	**3.4**: Linkers in a Part 2 answer (only when they do a job, about 6–8 per answer)
7 Nov	Too many linkers sound memorised. How many should I use?	**3.4**: same section (the remove test; avoid essay linkers)
8 Nov	"*he is / he was like a breath of fresh air*": I met him once in the past, so which one?	**4.3**: Mixed cards (past for the event, present for the person and your feeling now)

15 My Story Bank

My own real stories, ready to reuse. **One good story can answer many different cue cards.** In the prep minute, ask yourself: "*Which story from my bank fits this card?*"

15.1 My stories and where to use them

My story	Use it for these cue cards
Friday family movie night	a family tradition · a film you watched · time spent with family
Cartoons: Tom and Jerry, Pokémon	a TV programme / cartoon you liked as a child
Chor-police during power cuts	a game from childhood · a time the power went off · a time you were scared
Grandparents' village: fruit trees, river swimming	a place you visited as a child · the countryside · a river or lake · a summer holiday
Fishing with my youngest maternal uncle in the rainy season	an outdoor activity · something you learned from an older person · a family member · a rainy day
Rooftop picnic with dancing and songs	a party or celebration · an event you helped organise · a family event
Nanu's ghost stories at night	a story you heard as a child · an elderly person you know
Cycling for hours with a friend	something you did with a friend (see the Tanvir model in 4.4) · a sport or exercise
Fighting with my siblings	a time you had a disagreement · a family member
Cricket after school every day	a sport you played · a childhood hobby

15.2 Bangla → English words for my stories

Bangla	English
লোড শেডিং	**a power cut** (*load-shedding* is only used in South Asia) · *the electricity went off*
চোর পুলিশ	**chor-police**, *a game like hide-and-seek*
দাদু বাড়ি	**my (paternal) grandparents' house / village**
নানু / নানা	**my maternal grandmother / grandfather**
দাদু / দাদি	**my paternal grandfather / grandmother**
ছোট মামা	**my youngest maternal uncle**
চাচা / খালা / ফুপু	**my paternal uncle / maternal aunt / paternal aunt**
ছাদ	**the rooftop**
ফল পেড়ে খাওয়া	**pick fruit (straight from the tree)**
নদীতে গোসল	**swim / bathe in the river**
ভাইবোনের সাথে মারামারি	**squabble / fight with my siblings**
দুষ্টু	**naughty**
আম, কাঁঠাল, জাম	**mango, jackfruit, black plum**

15.3 My 2-stage method

Stage	What I do	Goal
Stage 1: simple sentences (now)	Write my ideas as a Bangla list → turn each idea into 1–3 **simple English sentences** → say them aloud	Build sentence making and **fluency** with correct basic grammar
Stage 1.5: join	Join 2 ideas with *and / but / so / because / when*	Make longer sentences without stopping
Stage 2: cue card version (later)	Pick 4 ideas → develop them in depth with the 6 layers (4.4) → about 270 words	Band 6.5–7 answers for specific cue cards and questions

How to practise a Stage 1 list:

1. Read one idea, cover it, and **say it aloud** in your own words.
2. Check three things: **past tense** (*fought, rode, caught, hid*), **he/she**, and **a/the**.
3. Once single ideas feel easy, **join two ideas** (Stage 1.5).
4. Then **talk through the whole list** without looking. Aim for 2 minutes without a long pause.
5. When that feels comfortable, move to Stage 2.

15.4 Childhood: Stage 1 (simple sentences)

1. When I was a child, I **played** cricket almost every day after school.
2. On Fridays, my whole family **watched** a movie together. We all **enjoyed** those moments a lot.
3. I regularly **watched** my favourite cartoons, like *Tom and Jerry* and *Pokémon*.
4. I **was** very naughty. I often **fought** with my brother and sister over small things.
5. We **had** a power cut almost every day. During power cuts, we **played** chor-police in the dark. One person **was** the thief and **hid** somewhere. The others **were** the police, and they **tried** to find the thief.
6. In the summer holidays, I **used to** visit my grandparents' village. There **were** many fruit trees there, like mango, jackfruit and black plum. My cousins and I **climbed** the trees and **picked** the fruit.
7. On holidays, I often **rode** my bicycle with my friend for hours.
8. There **was** a river near my grandparents' house. My cousins and I often **went** swimming there.
9. In the rainy season, I **went** fishing with my youngest maternal uncle. We **caught** many kinds of fish.
10. Sometimes we **had** small picnics on our rooftop. We **organised** dancing, singing and other events. Everyone in the family **took** part.
11. At night, my maternal grandmother **told** us stories, usually ghost stories. We **were** scared, but we **enjoyed** them a lot.

Irregular past verbs in this list: fight → **fought** · ride → **rode** · catch → **caught** · hide → **hid** · take → **took** · go → **went** · tell → **told** · have → **had**

15.5 Childhood: Stage 2 (cue card model, *Describe your childhood memories*, notes: **PAST**)

Built from my Bangla ideas: **4 ideas in depth**, about 270 words, 2 minutes.

> *"I'd like to talk about my childhood, which was probably the happiest time of my life.*
>
> *When I was a kid, I **used to** play cricket with the boys in my area almost every afternoon after school. To be honest, I was quite **naughty**, and I **would often** squabble with my brother and sister over silly things like the TV remote.*
>
> *Back then, we **used to** have **power cuts** almost every evening. **Whenever** the electricity went off, my cousins and I **would** play a game called chor-police in the dark. It's a bit like **hide-and-seek**: one person, the "thief", hides, and the others, the "police", have to find them. It was a little scary, but really exciting.*
>
> *My favourite memories, though, are from the summer holidays, when we **would** visit my **grandparents' village**. There were lots of fruit trees around the house, such as mango, jackfruit and black plum, and my cousins and I **would** climb them and **pick fruit straight from the branches**. There was also a river nearby, so we **spent hours swimming** there every afternoon.*
>
> *At night, my **maternal grandmother would** tell us ghost stories. We **were always getting** scared, but we never wanted her to stop!*
>
> ***Looking back**, I think those memories are so special because life was simple and the whole family spent time together. These days, children are busy with their phones, so they don't really have experiences like that **as often as we used to**."*

Notice: *used to* starts each new scene → *would* gives the details → *whenever*, *spent hours -ing* and *were always getting* add variety → it ends with **feelings + past vs now**.

15.6 Class sample: Best friend (corrected)

From my IELTS class handout (Class 3). The ideas are the teacher's; I fixed the grammar and wording. Adapt it to my real friend; don't memorise it.

> *"They say **a friend in need is a friend indeed**, and I think this saying is very true. True friends are rare nowadays, and you have to be really lucky to find one who **lives up to** this saying. I studied at [Dhaka College], where I met a friend named [Nusrat]. To me, she's **a gift from Allah**.*
>
> *On the very first day, when we weren't even friends yet, I helped her **overcome a serious problem**. After that, she started to talk to me more, and we soon became close. During our college life, we **used to hang out** together all the time. We **would chat for hours** and share our problems with each other, and we still do that today. I've found that she understands me **in a way that no one else does**.*
>
> *She's very **elegant** and **sensible**, and she's taught me a lot about dealing with **the harsh realities of life**. Whenever I face any trouble, she always **gives me good advice**. In every difficult period of my life, she's **stood by me like a deep-rooted tree**. She's never left my side, not even for a moment, and she inspires me in **every aspect of my life**.*
>
> *She has a simple personality. She loves simple, casual clothes, home-cooked food and **a peaceful lifestyle**. We still meet in our free time, and whenever I see her, **I'm over the moon**. She's like **a breath of fresh air** in my **hectic** life. As I said, true friends are hard to find, and I feel **fortunate to have** a friend like her."*

Main fixes from the handout: *like a fresh air* → **a breath of fresh air** · *I feel like I am over the moon* → **I'm over the moon** · *concrete reality of life* → **the harsh realities of life** · *true and promising friends* → **true**

friends · *a friend which implies its meaning* → **one who lives up to this saying** · *stood beside me / never left me* → **has stood by me / has never left my side** · *gossip* → **chat** · *home food* → **home-cooked food** · *a nice behavior* → **good manners** · *doesn't have bad habit* → **any bad habits** · he/she mixed → **one pronoun all the way through**